Sure Thing

By David Ives

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *It's probably no surprise -- guys are completely clueless when it comes to meeting women. They often resort to horrible canned pick-up lines: "Do you believe in love at first sight."*
ACTRESS: *And women are just as awkward when it comes to accepting the sincere interest of a member of the opposite sex. Instead, women become suspicious: Why is he talking to me? What does he want? Do I need my mace?*
ACTOR: *It's a wonder anyone gets together at all! Wouldn't it be great if you had the opportunity to instantly replay all those times when you've said the wrong thing?*
ACTRESS: *If you actually had a second chance to make a good first impression?*
TOGETHER*: Sure Thing by David Ives*

Betty, reading at the table. An empty chair opposite her. Bill enters.
Every time a bell rings, the scene begins at the last awkward moment – a Do-Over.

BILL: (Pgs 1-18) Excuse me. Is this chair taken?

BETTY: Excuse me?

BILL: Is this taken?

BETTY: Yes it is.

BILL: Oh. Sorry.

BETTY: Sure thing. *(A bell rings softly)*

BILL: Excuse me. Is this chair taken?

BETTY: No, but I'm expecting somebody very shortly.

BILL: Would you mind if I sit here till he or she comes?

BETTY: *(glances at her watch)* They seem to be pretty late. . .

BILL: You never know who you might be turning down.

BETTY: Sorry. Nice try, though.

BILL: Sure thing. *(Bell)*

BILL: Is this chair taken?

BETTY: No, it's not.

BILL: Would you mind if I sit here?

BETTY: No. Go ahead.

BILL: Thanks. *(He sits. She continues reading)* Everyplace else seems to be taken.

BETTY: Mm-hm.

BILL: Great place.

BETTY: Mm-hm.

BILL: What's the book?

BETTY: I just wanted to read in quiet, if you don't mind.

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BILL: No, sure thing. *(Bell)*

BILL: What's the book?

BETTY: The Sound and the Fury.

BILL: Oh. Faulkner.

BETTY: Have you read it?

BILL: Not . . . actually. I've sure read about it though. It's supposed to be great.

BETTY: It is great.

BILL: I hear it's great. *(Small pause)* Waiter? *(Bell)*

BETTY: Have you read it?

BILL: Yeah, I read it in college.

BETTY: Where was college?

BILL: I went to Oral Roberts University. *(Bell)*

BETTY: Where was college?

BILL: I was lying. I never really went to college. I just like to party. *(Bell)*

BETTY: Where was college?

BILL: Harvard.

BETTY: Do you like Faulkner?

BILL: I love Faulkner. I spent a whole winter reading him once.

BETTY: I've just started.

BILL: I was so excited after ten pages that I went out and bought everything else he wrote. One of the greatest reading experiences of my life. I mean, all that incredible psychological understanding. Page after page of gorgeous prose. His profound grasp of the mystery of time and human existence. The smells of the earth . . . What do you think?

BETTY: I think it's pretty boring. *(Bell)*

BILL: What's the book?

BETTY: *The Sound and the Fury.*

BILL: Oh! Faulkner!

BETTY: Do you like Faulkner?

BILL: I love Faulkner.

BETTY: He's incredible.

BILL: I spent a whole winter reading him once.

BETTY: I was so excited after ten pages that I went out and bought everything else he wrote.

BILL: All that incredible psychological understanding.

BETTY: And the prose is so gorgeous.

BILL: And the way he's grasped the mystery of time --

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BETTY: -- and human existence. I can't believe I've waited this long to read him.

BILL: You never know. You might not have liked him before.

BETTY: That's true.

BILL: You might not have been ready for him. You have to hit these things at the right moment or it's no good.

BETTY: That's happening to me.

BILL: It's all in the timing. *(Small pause)* My name's Bill, by the way.

BETTY: I'm Betty. **BILL:** Hi.

BETTY: Hi. *(Small pause)*

BILL: Yes, I thought reading Faulkner was . . . a great experience.

BETTY: Yes. *(Small pause)*

BILL: *The Sound and the Fury* . . . *(Another small pause)*

BETTY: Well. Onwards and upwards. *(She goes back to her book)*

BILL: Waiter ? *(Bell)*

BILL: My name's Bill, by the way. **BETTY:** I'm Betty.

BILL: Do you come here a lot? **BETTY:** Every once in a while. Do you?

BILL: Not much anymore. Not as much as I used to. Before my nervous breakdown. *(Bell)*

BILL: Do you come here a lot? **BETTY:** Why are you asking?

BILL: Just interested.

BETTY: Are you really interested, or do you just want to pick me up?

BILL: No, I'm really interested.

BETTY: Why would you be interested in whether I come here a lot?

BILL: Just . . . getting acquainted.

BETTY: Maybe you're only interested for the sake of making small talk long enough to ask me back to your place to listen to some music, only all you ***really*** want to do is [you know] which you won't do very well -- after which you'll go into the bathroom and pee very loudly. And then you'll proceed to lie back down beside me and confess that you've got a girlfriend named Stephanie who's away at medical school for a year, and that you've been involved

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with her -- off and on -- in what you'll call a very "intricate" relationship, for the past *seven* YEARS. None of which interests me, mister!

BILL: Okay. *(Bell)*

BILL: Do you come here a lot?

BETTY: Every other day I think.

BILL: I come here quite a lot and I don't remember seeing you.

BETTY: I guess we must be on different schedules.

BILL: Amazing how you can live right next door to somebody and never even know it.

BETTY: I know.

BILL: City life.

BETTY: It's crazy.

BILL: You weren't waiting for somebody when I came in, were you?

BETTY: Actually, I was.

BILL: Oh. Boyfriend?

BETTY: Sort of.

BILL: What's a sort-of boyfriend?

BETTY: My husband.

BILL: Ah-ha. *(Bell)*

BILL: You weren't waiting for somebody when I came in, were you?

BETTY: No, just reading.

BILL: Sort of a sad occupation for a Friday night, isn't it? Reading here, all by yourself?

BETTY: Do you think so?

BILL: Well sure. I mean, what's a good-looking woman like you doing out alone on a Friday night?

BETTY: Trying to keep away from lines like that.

BILL: No, listen *(Bell)*

BILL: You weren't waiting for somebody when I came in, were you?

BETTY: No, just reading.

BILL: Sort of a sad occupation for a Friday night, isn't it? Reading here all by yourself?

BETTY: I guess it is, in a way.

BILL: What's a good-looking woman like you doing out alone on a Friday night anyway? No

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offense, but . . .

BETTY: I just recently ended a relationship.

BILL: I'm sorry *(Small pause)* Well listen, since reading by yourself is such a sad occupation for a Friday night, would you like to go elsewhere?

BETTY: No . . .

BILL: Do something else?

BETTY: No thanks.

BILL: I was headed out to the movies.

BETTY: I don't think so.

BILL: Big chance to let Faulkner catch his breath. All those long sentences gets him pretty tired.

BETTY: Thanks anyway. I appreciate the invitation.

BILL: Sure thing. *(Bell)*

BILL: You weren't waiting for somebody when I came in, were you?

BETTY: No, just reading.

BILL: Sort of a sad occupation for a Friday night, isn't it? Reading here all by yourself?

BETTY: I guess I was trying to think of it as existentially romantic. You know cappuccino, great literature, rainy night . . .

BILL: That only works in Paris. We could hop the late plane to Paris. Get on a Concorde. Find a café . . .

BETTY: I'm a little short of plane fare tonight.

BILL: Damn it, so am I.

BETTY: To tell you the truth, I was headed to the movies after I finished this section. Would you like to come along?

BILL: That's a very nice offer but . . .

BETTY: Uh-huh. Girlfriend?

BILL: No, I don't have a girlfriend. Not if you mean the [witch] I dumped last night. *(Bell)*

BETTY: Girlfriend?

BILL: Sort of. Sort of.

BETTY: What's a sort-of girlfriend?

BILL: My mother. *(Bell)*

BILL: I just ended a relationship, actually.

BETTY: I'm sorry to hear it.

BILL: This is my first night out alone in a long time. I feel a little bit at sea, to tell you the truth.

BETTY: So you didn't stop to talk because you're a Moonie, or you have some weird political

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affiliation ?

BILL: Nope. Straight-down-the-ticket Republican. *(Bell)* Straight-down-the-ticket Democrat. *(Bell)* Can I tell you something about politics? *(Bell)* I like to think of myself as a citizen of the universe. *(Bell)* I'm unaffiliated.

BETTY: That's a relief. So am I.

BILL: I vote my beliefs. **BETTY:** Labels are not important.

BILL: Labels are not important, exactly. I believe a man is what he is. *(Bell)* A person is what he is. *(Bell)* A person is . . . what they are.

BETTY: I think so too.

BILL: So what if I admire Trotsky? *(Bell)* So what if I once had a total-body liposuction? *(Bell)* So what if I once spent a year in the Peace Corps? I was acting on my convictions.

BETTY: Sure.

BILL: You can't just hang a sign on a person.

BETTY: Absolutely. I'll bet you're a Scorpio. *(Many bells ring)*

(Simultaneously) **BILL:** Y'know I was headed to the . . . **BETTY:** I was thinking about . . .

BILL: I'm sorry. **BETTY:** No, go ahead.

BILL: I was going to say that I was headed to the movies in a little while, and . . .

BETTY: So was I. **BILL:** The Woody Allen festival?

BETTY: Just up the street. **BILL:** Do you like the early ones?

BETTY: I think anybody who doesn't ought to be run off the planet.

BILL: How many times have you seen Bananas? **BETTY:** Eight times.

BILL: Twelve. So are you still interested? *(Long pause)*

BETTY: Do you like Entenmann's crumb cake?

BILL: Last night I went out at two in the morning to get one. *(Small pause)* Did you have an Etch-a-Sketch as a child?

BETTY: Yes! And do you like Brussels sprouts? *(Small pause)*

BILL: I think they're gross. **BETTY:** They are gross!

BILL: Do you still believe in marriage despite current sentiments against it?

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BETTY: Yes.

BETTY: Three of them.

BETTY: Harvard, Vassar, and Brown.

BETTY: Yes.

BETTY: Yes.

BILL: Do you still want to go to the movies?

BILL and BETTY *(together)*: Waiter!

BILL: And children?

BILL: Two girls and a boy.

BILL: And will you love me?

BILL: And cherish me forever?

BETTY: Sure thing.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
2023 National Qualifier
FL State Qualifier
IL State Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier
SD State Finalist
UT State Finalist

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